Lesson 7 — The Bench by the Stairs

Part 5 of 12: Weak can, hard can't, and have to

Level: B1 (seventh step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

3.7 Weak can, hard can't, and have to → hafta (listen to `05-can-and-hafta.mp3`)

Modals are small words that carry the whole meaning of the sentence, and small words are exactly the ones English swallows. Two traps here, and the first one changes the meaning completely.

1. can is weak; can't is strong.

In a normal positive sentence can is unstressed and its vowel collapses to /ə/. The negative keeps a full, long vowel — and in British English it is a different vowel altogether:

WRITTEN	WHAT YOU HEAR	WHICH VOWEL
I can fix it.	/aɪ kən ˈfɪks ɪt/	short, weak /ə/
I can't fix it.	/aɪ kɑːnt ˈfɪks ɪt/	long /ɑː/
She can come.	/ʃi kən ˈkʌm/	weak
She can't come.	/ʃi kɑːnt ˈkʌm/	long

So you are not listening for the t — in fast speech the t often disappears before another consonant. You are listening for the length of the vowel and for where the stress falls. In I can fix it the stress is on fix; in I can't fix it it is on can't.

Can takes its full sound /kæn/ back at the end of a sentence: Yes, I can.

2. have to → **/ˈhæftə/**, has to → **/ˈhæstə/**.

Before another verb, the v turns into an f — because t is voiceless and the v follows it round:

WRITTEN	WHAT YOU ACTUALLY HEAR
I have to go.	/aɪ ˈhæftə ˈgəʊ/
She has to learn.	/ʃi ˈhæstə ˈlɜːn/
We had to wait.	/wi ˈhætə ˈweɪt/
You don't have to be quick.	/jə ˈdəʊnt ˈhæftə bi ˈkwɪk/

3. must loses its t too, before a consonant: you must not touch arrives as /jə məs nɒt ˈtʌtʃ/.

In the audio you hear each line twice, and then a test: say whether what you hear is can or can't. Get that one right and you will stop agreeing to things nobody offered.